# Getting started

Hive Notes is a simple app for recording hive inspections on your phone - colony strength, queen, brood, stores, pests, treatments, notes and photos. It is a single file, works without signal in the apiary, and needs no account.

## 1. Open the file in your browser

The app is the file **hive-notes.html**. It must be opened in a web browser (Chrome or Safari), **not** a text or document viewer.

1. Save **hive-notes.html** to your phone (from email, Google Drive, iCloud, or USB).
2. **Android:** open the **Files** app, find the file, **long-press** it, then choose **Open with > Chrome**.
3. **iPhone:** open the **Files** app, tap the file, tap **Share**, then choose **Safari** (or open it from a link in Safari).
4. If you see lines of code instead of the app, it opened in a viewer - go back and pick Chrome or Safari.

## 2. Add it to your home screen

- **Android (Chrome):** tap the **three-dot menu** (top right) > **Add to Home screen** > Add.
- **iPhone (Safari):** tap **Share** (square with an arrow) > **Add to Home Screen** > Add.
- A Hive Notes icon now appears like any other app.

## 3. Using it offline

Open Hive Notes from the home-screen icon. Everything - adding hives, inspections and photos, viewing history - works with **no internet**. Always open it the same way (same icon, same browser) so you see the same data.

## 4. Everyday use

- Tap **+ Add hive** to create a hive (name and optional notes).
- Tap a hive to see its history, then **+ Inspection**.
- The form has 3 tabs: **Colony** (date, weather, strength, queen), **Health** (brood, honey, pests, treatments) and **Notes & photos**. Use Next / Back, then Save.
- Tap a photo thumbnail to see it full size. Delete inspections or hives from their screens (you will be asked to confirm).

## 5. Voice input

Handy with gloves on. Tap a **mic** next to any box to dictate into it, or the mic in the top bar for commands.

- The first time, your browser asks for **microphone permission** - tap **Allow**.

- Speech recognition is provided by the browser and, in Chrome, **usually needs internet**. Without signal just type - the rest of the app still works offline.
- Example commands: *"open hive 2"*, *"add hive"*, *"add inspection"*, *"strong"*, *"queen seen"* / *"no queen"*, *"sunny windy"*, *"brood solid"*, *"honey full"*, *"next"*, *"back"*, *"save"*, *"cancel"*, *"notes queen cells on frame 3"*.

## 6. Backup: export & import

Backup is under the **?** icon in the top bar.

- **Export backup** downloads a file named like *hive-notes-backup-2026-10-17.json* containing all hives, inspections and photos. Email it to yourself or save it to Drive / iCloud.
- **Import backup** restores from that file. You can **merge** it with what is on the phone, or **replace** everything (asked to confirm).
- Use this to move to a new phone or browser. Export regularly!

## 7. Troubleshooting

- **File shows code / will not open:** open it with Chrome or Safari, not a viewer (see step 1).
- **My data is missing:** data is stored **only on this phone, in this browser**. A different browser, a different copy of the file, private/incognito mode, or clearing browser/site data shows an empty app. Go back to the original browser or import a backup.
- **"Storage is full":** the browser allows about 5 MB - roughly **50-100 photos**. Export a backup, then delete old inspections or photos.
- **Mic does nothing:** allow microphone access in browser settings, check you have internet, or type instead.

**Remember:** Hive Notes never uploads your data anywhere. You are in control - and responsible for backups.

# How Your Data Is Saved

A plain-language guide to keeping your hive records safe.

## 1. Saving happens on your phone

1. Your hives, inspections and photos are kept **on your phone**, inside the browser (Chrome or Safari).
2. When you tap **Save hive** on a new hive, or **Save** on the last tab of an inspection, it is stored straight away. There is nothing else to save.
3. Deleting a hive or inspection also takes effect straight away.
4. If you leave an inspection form **without** tapping Save, that inspection is **not** kept.
5. Nothing is sent to the internet. That also means: if the phone is lost, or the browser data is cleared, the records are gone - unless you have a backup.

## 2. What the backup file is

1. A backup is **one simple file** holding all your hives, inspections and photos - a bit like a spreadsheet file, but for this app.
2. It is named like **hive-notes-backup-2026-10-17.json** (the date you made it). The ending **.json** is just the file type.
3. You do not need to open it - phones may show it as text or say they cannot open it. That is normal. It is only for importing back into Hive Notes.

## 3. Make a backup (Export)

1. Open Hive Notes.
2. Tap the **?** icon in the top bar.
3. Tap **Export backup**.
4. The phone downloads the file. You may see a "Download" message - tap OK or Download if asked.
5. Where it lands: **Android** - Files app > **Downloads**. **iPhone** - Files app > **Downloads** (Safari may ask first; tap Download).

## 4. Keep the backup in Google Drive

1. Open the **Google Drive** app.
2. Go to the **Beehive app** folder (or any folder you like).
3. Tap the **+** button, then **Upload**.
4. Find the backup file in **Downloads** and tap it. Wait until the upload finishes.
5. Do this regularly - for example once a month, or after a big inspection day.

### 5. Restore on a new phone (Import)

1. On the new phone, open the **Google Drive** app, find the backup file, tap the three dots next to it and choose **Download**.
2. Open Hive Notes in Chrome or Safari (see "Getting started").
3. Tap the **?** icon, then **Import backup**.
4. Pick the backup file. The app tells you how many hives and inspections it found.
5. Choose **Merge** (keep what is on the phone and add the backup) or **Replace** (delete what is on the phone and use only the backup). Replace asks you to confirm again.

> **Tip:** keep the newest backup. Each export holds **everything**, so you only ever need the latest file.

# Which Phones It Works On

Quick guide to check your phone before you start.

### 1. A modern phone browser

1. **Android:** use **Chrome**.
2. **iPhone:** use **Safari**.
3. Keep the browser up to date for the best results.

### 2. Phones that will not work well

1. **Very old phones:** roughly **Android 7 or older**, or iPhones older than about **iOS 14**.
2. **Photo notes** need a phone with a camera.
3. The screen must be big enough to read comfortably. Small feature phones or button phones will not work.

### 3. Simple check before buying

1. On your phone, open **Chrome** (Android) or **Safari** (iPhone).
2. Go to any website, for example a news site.
3. If it loads and looks normal, Hive Notes should work on that phone.